



The heartbreak of not qualifying for the 2008 Olympics was replaced by the triumph of consecutive Olympic bronze medals, breaking a 41-year drought.

The second bronze, from Paris 2024, though, came with a bittersweet aftertaste. **A narrow defeat to Germany in the semifinal dashed India's hopes of reclaiming gold.**

"When we went to Paris, we were confident we could make the final. Our preparation and team unity were on point. So when that faith was lost, disappointment was inevitable. But the Olympics is not a stage to dwell on defeat. We needed to focus on the next opportunity, and that was the bronze medal match," Sreejesh said, his words tinged with regret.

Just as he hoped, the team regrouped, defeating Spain 2-1 in the bronze medal match, ensuring a glorious farewell for Sreejesh in his final international appearance. Sreejesh admits his decision to retire was made long before the Paris Games, though he initially planned to

**Hues of glory:** On the teapoy in Sreejesh's home, three glittering treasures lie in wait — the Tokyo '20 and Paris '24 Olympic bronze medals, and the Hangzhou '22 Asian Games gold. These symbols of triumph are more than just decorations; they're beacons of inspiration, fuelling Sreejesh's hope that they'll spark a fire in the hearts of young kids. THULASIKAKKAT

announce it afterwards. However, the weight of that secret affected his focus during the Olympic preparation camp, prompting him to share it sooner.

"I always wanted to retire on a big stage, and there's nothing bigger than the Olympics. Everyone told me to announce it afterwards, but as the tournament neared, it became a distraction. So, I told my coach about it.

"Before the Olympics, we had trips to Switzerland and the Netherlands. I usually speak first in team meetings, but in Holland, I decided to speak last. That's when I told the team, 'This will be my last tournament. All of you will have more chances, but this is my final one.' A week before the Olympics, I made it public, and then it was done," Sreejesh recounted.

A highlight of India's Paris 2024

hockey campaign was the quarterfinal win against Great Britain, where the team defended with just 10 men for nearly three-quarters of the game after key defender Amit Rohidas was shown a red card. India dragged the game to a penalty shootout, and once again, Sreejesh rose to the occasion. He saved one British penalty and forced another wide, securing his team's victory.

**For all its inherent unfairness, a penalty shootout is often a goalkeeper's best chance to shine.**

With the odds stacked against them, a save in a tiebreaker can propel a goalkeeper into folklore. Sreejesh has had his fair share of such moments, starting with his crucial saves against Pakistan in the 2011 Asian Champions Trophy.

His success in shootouts is even more impressive given that his career